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The Stone Age—a Wandering Life

Topics covered

- The Old and Middle Stone Ages—the sources
- The hunter-gatherers
- Hunter-gatherers in India

This food needs to be cut.

Roast chicken

Mango

Which of these two would do it better?

Stone

Knife

Write here why: .....

The knife would cut the food better than the stone, because it has a **sharp edge**. It is a **tool** that helps you to cut food. The earliest people also made tools with sharp edges. Their tools are some sources that tell us about them.

THE OLD AND MIDDLE STONE AGES—THE SOURCES

Tools

Most tools were made of stone. Toolmakers hit one stone with another stone until it had a sharp edge. Early tools that could be held comfortably in a human hand are called 'hand axes'. Slowly tools got better—they became thinner and sharper.

An early human being making a stone tool—notice the small pieces of chipped-off stones lying on the ground.

An ancient hand axe—notice the shape and the sharp edges.

Some tools, like needles, were made from bones or the antlers of deer.

Early people used their tools for hunting, fishing, cutting meat, cleaning animal skins, digging and sewing. Because so many stone tools have been found, this period is called the **Stone Age**. It was a very long period of time. It had three phases, depending on the type of tools that were used.

The phases of the Stone Age	The tools made and used
Paleolithic Age or Old Stone Age	Stone tools, like hand axes, which had sharp edges. Bone and wooden tools were also used.
Mesolithic Age or Middle Stone Age	Small, sharp stone tools that could be fitted onto wooden arrows or spears
Neolithic Age or New Stone Age	Finer stone tools that were polished to make them sharper. Bone and wooden tools continued to be used.

You will learn about the New Stone Age in the next chapter.

Did you Know?

Two scientists made thousands of stone tools to understand more about early people. They were able to use the tools to cut meat. They realized that making stone tools was hard work and took a lot of practice.

Shelters

Caves used as shelters have also been found. People probably lived in them when it was wet or cold. Some caves have the bones of animals. This tells us which animals were hunted and eaten by these people.

A cave with a low entrance that was used as shelter in the Stone Age

Art

In several parts of the world, drawings and paintings have been found on the walls of caves.

A Stone Age cave painting showing people and animals

These mainly show animals, though some show people as well. The colours are still quite bright, even though the paintings are very old. It is very dark inside caves, so people probably used fire to give them enough light to paint by. These drawings and paintings tell us about the animals the people had around them and also how they hunted them.

THE HUNTER-GATHERERS

From these sources, experts can guess what the life of early people was like. At that time people did not know how to grow their food, so their main aim was to find food to be able to **survive** (stay alive). We call these people **hunter-gatherers**. They lived by hunting wild animals, fishing, and by searching for and gathering foods such as fruits, nuts, vegetables and honey.

At that time the earth was rich in plant and animal life. The hunter-gatherers depended on this environment for their food. They moved from place to place, wandering over large areas in search of food and water. They had to be near water, but also near areas where

their food could be found. They had a very good understanding of their environment and were very **skilled** (skill=to be able to do something well) at what they needed to do.

The men hunted in groups. They observed and understood the animals they hunted—where they were to be found and how they lived. Some animals they hunted were the elephant, the buffalo, the giraffe, different types of deer and smaller animals like wild pigs. Animals were probably chased until they became tired and could be killed or until they fell into a deep pit. Perhaps they were chased to a wet, muddy area where they got stuck. Stone tools were then used to kill them and cut the meat so that it could be carried home.

Spears had stone heads and a wooden handle. Arrows were made of wood and had a stone arrowhead.

The women looked after the children. They also gathered food like fruits, roots, berries and seeds. They knew which plants and seeds could be eaten, when the fruits and berries ripened and where they grew. They used pointed stones and sticks as tools to dig up the roots.

The women gathered fruits, roots and berries. They also looked after the children.

All these were very important skills for the hunter-gatherers.

The hunter-gatherers lived in groups of many people because they needed each other—to hunt, to carry food home, to gather food and to look after children.

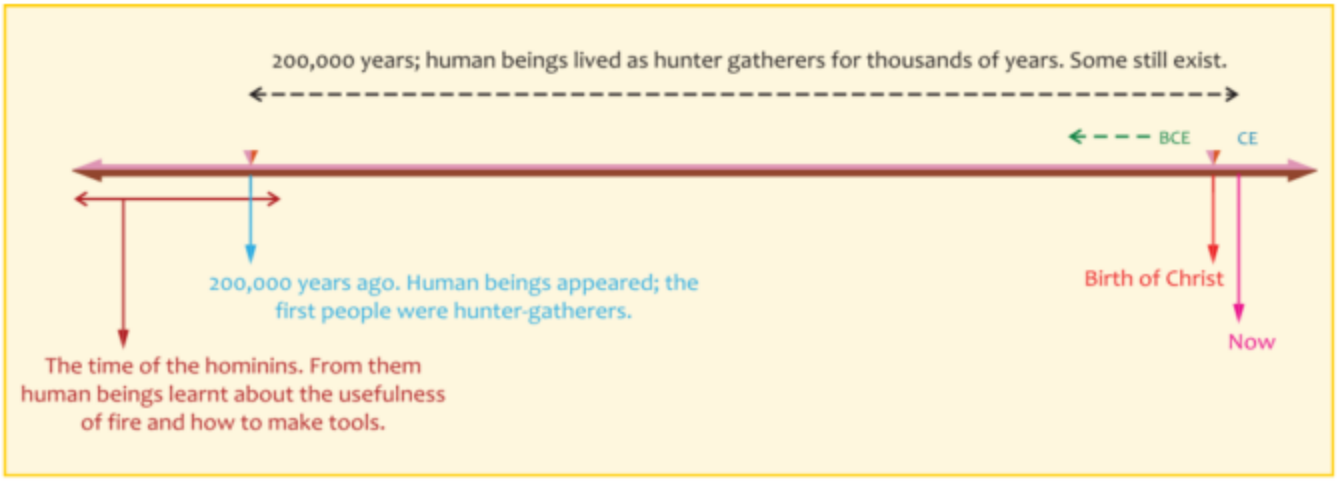
Though wandering about in search of food was not easy, the hunting-gathering way of life survived for thousands of years. This is because these people knew how to live well in their environment and because they were very skilled at what they did.

Discuss

Like the hunter-gatherers, people today also belong to groups.

- Which groups do you belong to?
- How they are important for you?

The timeline shows you how long ago people appeared and how long they lived as hunter-gatherers.



Think and answer

Do you think that the Stone Age people were less intelligent and clever than people today? Why?

Did you Know?

'Persistence hunting' is an type of ancient hunting in which hunters chase their prey for many hours until it is exhausted. When it stops to rest or drink water, the hunters kill it with their spears. The Bushmen of the Kalahari Desert in Africa still use this method of hunting.

TP HUNTER-GATHERERS IN INDIA

Stone tools of early human beings have been found in several places in India too. India also has one of the largest collections of rock paintings in the world. Most of these are in the caves of the Satpura and Vindhya Hills in central India. The most famous rock paintings are at **Bhimbetka** in Madhya Pradesh.

A cave painting from Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh—can you see their hunting tools?

In the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, small groups of people still live like the earliest people, surviving through only hunting-gathering. However, modern influences have changed their lives. Their numbers have come down a lot in the last 200 years. It is difficult to say whether these hunter-gatherers will still be there by the end of this century.

Did you Know?

Recent discoveries of Stone Age tools in West Bengal tell us that Stone Age people lived here thousands of years ago. Stone Age tools had earlier been discovered in parts of the Deccan plateau.

Values and Life Skills

People have always learnt from those who lived earlier.

- Do you think human beings learnt important things from the hominins?
- Why is it important to understand the lives of early people?

REMEMBER

1. The main sources that tell us about the earliest people are their tools, bones, their shelters and cave paintings.
2. The earliest human beings were hunter-gatherers.
3. Hunter-gatherers lived in groups. They moved from place to place in search of food and water.
4. Hunter-gatherers were very skilled and had a good understanding of their environment.
5. Hunter-gatherers are still found in some parts of the world, including in India.

NEW WORDS

Tool	anything that you can hold in your hand, such as a hammer or a knife, which helps to do a piece of work
Survive	stay alive
Skilled	able to do something well
Persistence	continuing to try to do something

EXERCISES

A. Complete the following sentences in your notebook.

1. Two things that human beings learnt from hominins were .....
2. The earliest people are called hunter-gatherers because .....

3. Some animals that the hunter-gatherers hunted were
   .....
4. Some foods that the hunter-gatherers gathered were
   .....
5. The period when early human beings lived is called the Stone Age because
   .....

B. Choose the correct answer.

1. The hunter-gatherers led a wandering life in search of food / because they liked travelling.
2. As the years went by, the tools of the hunter-gatherers remained the same / became better.
3. The hand-axe is called by this name because it could be held comfortably in a person's hand / a person's hand could be hurt by using it.
4. Cave art of the early people has been found only in India / in many parts of the world.
5. The numbers of hunter-gatherers in the Andaman and Nicobar Islands are slowly growing / have come down a lot in the last 200 years.

C. Match the following.

A	B
1. *Homo sapiens*	a. the upright man
2. Old Stone Age	b. finer stone tools that were polished to make them sharper
3. Middle Stone Age	c. the thinking man
4. New Stone Age	d. sharp stone tools, fixed on wooden arrows or spears
5. *Homo erectus*	e. stone hand axes that had sharp edges

D. You be the teacher!

Here are some answers. Write the questions for them in your notebook.

1. Bones, tools, shelters and cave paintings.
2. Of stones, bones and antlers.
3. In the Vindhya and Satpura hills. Bhimbetka in Madhya Pradesh has the best known ones.
4. Some skills were making tools, hunting animals, gathering plant food, understanding the environment, drawing and painting and living well with other people.
5. In the Andaman and Nicobar Islands.

E. Answer the following questions.

1. What do we call the people who lived on earth before human beings?
2. How did the hunter-gatherers make their stone tools?
3. What did the hunter-gatherers use their tools for?
4. Write three or four sentences about caves as a source of information about the hunter-gatherers. Mention the remains found there and the art.
5. What was the main aim of the hunter-gatherers?
6. How did men and women divide their responsibilities during the Stone Age? Write a short paragraph to explain.

THINGS TO DO

SI A. On your own

Cave artists used colours made from natural materials. To understand how well they used their environment, do similar paintings on stones. Use:

- Yellow turmeric mixed in water
- Red ochre mixed in water. (You will get it in a shop that sells earthen flower pots.)
- Charcoal or soft coal for black lines

B. Picture study

Talk about the following:

1. What is the difference in the materials used to make these tools?
2. Which tool would be easier to hold? Why?
3. What are the similarities between the food of the Stone Age people and people today?

SI C. In a group

1. Try some magic! Early human beings used stones called flints to light fires. You can also create sparks from stones. Take two stones (not bricks) and strike them against each other in a dark corner. You may be able to see the magical sparks. Make sure that you have an adult with you when you do this.
2. In groups of four or five, spend about 15-20 minutes talking about whether 'Stone Age people had a carefree and happy life'. What has your group decided and why? Present the result of your discussion to the rest of the class.

TP WEBLINK

- Lascaux cave in France: http://www.lascaux.culture.fr/index.php?fichier=00.xml (Accessed on 20 July 2017)